AMRO. My team and I, therefore, spent many hours at the RBI working with key officials.[1]

These interactions gave me an opportunity to observe at close quarters the professionalism of RBI officials at every level. As a participant on several RBI committees, I saw the meticulous detail of scenario planning exercises, the thoughtfulness with which committees deliberated key monetary policy and economic issues, and the transparency with which data was shared and decisions were made.

In September 2013, I went to bid Governor Subbarao farewell. We had enjoyed a very cordial relationship. Financial inclusion was a subject very close to his heart. In addition to discussing issues related to banking, I often met him to share learnings and experiences from my journeys to the villages. When he had been appointed, given his background in the Ministry of Finance, many had thought that he would find it difficult to take an independent stand against the ministry. I shared this with him. He laughed merrily and said, 'Meera, maybe that's what many people initially thought. But the RBI is not about any one man. Many excellent colleagues have supported my decisions. *The RBI is an upright, independent and magnificent institution – we make our decisions in the best interests of the country.*'

As the demonetization saga unfolded, people began to ask on whose advice the Prime Minister had made this major decision.

The Finance Minister, the Chief Economic Advisor, the Vice Chairman of NITI Aayog,[2] all had been very silent during the initial days of demonetization. Their obvious discomfort in answering media questions led to rumours that none of them had been consulted about the move.

However, it was the silence of the RBI Governor, Urjit Patel, that raised the most concern.

In the weeks after the demonetization announcement, questions were repeatedly raised by the public, the media, the Supreme Court, and Parliament's Public Accounts Committee[3] (PAC), as to how the